



to be herding animals. Few Kazakhs these days live as nomadic shepherds, traveling with their animals around the grasslands of the steppes. Around half of the population live in crowded cities, while the other half

live settled lives in rural areas where there is plenty of space but often no electricity or running water. Modern Kazakhs recall their former lives fondly, even building *yurts* (traditional huts) for use on special occasions.



COOKING AND EATING

At the very centre of the *yurt* is the hearth, with a cauldron called a *kazan* suspended above it. On the steppes, Kazakhs rely on meat such as mutton or horse, dairy products, and bread. Vegetables are very rarely available. Meals traditionally start with *chai* (tea), which may be accompanied by bread, nuts, and sweets as appetizers.

Bundled up snugly, this baby will be warm and comfortable even while the family is traveling.



THE BIG MATCH

The people of the steppes invented a number of games that were played on horseback. *Kokpar* is a little like polo and is played with a headless sheep's or goat's carcass. Two teams line up at either end of a large meadow and charge forward. In this exciting game the players have to grab the goat and drop it into their goal.

FELT

The *yurt* is covered in one or two layers of felt. Kazakh women are famous for their felt, which they make by pounding wool in hot water, then rolling and compressing it until durable and waterproof.



A LOVE OF HORSES

Some archaeologists believe that human beings first learned to ride horses on the steppes of Central Asia as long as 6,000 years ago. Nomadic Kazakhs—heirs to this tradition—are accomplished riders and some are capable of shooting arrows accurately from the back of a moving horse. In the past, it is said, children often learned to ride before they could walk.

